

« AIFF is rethinking youth development timeline »

KALYAN CHAUBEY

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

With rankings tumbling, results fading, and the ISL's future uncertain, Indian football faces a reckoning.

In an exclusive interview with Sportstar, AIFF president Kalyan Chaubey shares his vision to spark a revival.

What is the AIFF's strategy to improve India's FIFA ranking?

To improve our FIFA ranking, the National Team must win matches, and for that, it has to score goals.

In the last 16 matches, the senior men's team has managed only one win (3-0 vs Maldives) and scored just seven goals, averaging less than 0.5 goals per game.

The AIFF can only facilitate, strategise and ensure the National

Team plays in every FIFA window. Camps, training sessions, and opponents are selected based on inputs from the Chief Coach.

India's age-group teams have also failed to qualify for the FIFA U-17 or U-20 World Cups or even continental tournaments. How can this be fixed?

Youth development must begin early. Players under 11 should be exposed to football to build basic technique. By 12-13, they should be preparing for competition; 14-15 is for regular match play.

Ages 16-17 are for high-performance training, and by 18-20, players should be transitioning to professional setups.

Evaluating the ones who are playing today, we must ask: Did we

have a structured youth development system 10 years ago? If not, we must ensure today's youngsters don't face the same gap.

The new MRA draft from FSDL proposes a 10-year moratorium on promotion and relegation in the ISL. Doesn't this violate the 2019 roadmap signed with the AFC?

FSDL submitted the proposal on March 5, and it was discussed in our Executive Committee meeting on April 7. A counter-proposal was then sent to FSDL.

Since the matter is sub judice, I cannot comment further.

Why is the ISL not listed in the AIFF's official calendar?

FSDL has yet to officially announce ISL's start and end dates. However,